

Once, Sven allowed a backpacker who looked like supermodel Gisele Bündchen – but who was really a bludger – to sleep on our second-floor landing for a month, free of charge. I was lucky that was the worst housemate experience I had; most people who have done the share-house thing have horror stories. *Domain* columnist Danny Katz, in an article called ‘How to deal with a housemate’s partner’, recalls his university share house with ‘stoner dude’ Norbert, who was often idle on the couch with a bong and a pizza; together, they would watch TV and pick their toenails, and build little pyramids of picked toenails on the coffee table.

That said, living in a share house deep into your 20s and 30s is an option for those who want to save. While the initial goal for moving out of your parents’ place was freedom – to have Coco Pops for breakfast every morning, a partner staying over as often as you wish and your own peace and quiet – now the aim is to squirrel away as much money as possible. The average weekly wage in Australia is a tick over \$1500 gross; when you crunch the numbers – which, be mindful, are in a constant state of flux – of renting on your own, Sven suddenly equals great savings.

‘Housing stress’ is frequently defined as spending more than 30 per cent of your income on paying for accommodation, be it rent or a mortgage. A 30:40 ratio is often used by data-crunchers as a yardstick for housing stress. If a household’s income sits in the bottom 40 per cent of incomes, and they spend more than 30 per cent of that income on funding a roof over their heads, they are classed as being under housing stress.

Compare these house and apartment median rents across Australia to the national average wage of just over \$1500 – which is before tax, so you have less in your take-home pay – and even Norbert seems more appealing:

Median house rent (per week)

Sydney \$550

Melbourne \$425

Brisbane \$400

Adelaide \$370

Perth \$350

Hobart \$395

Darwin \$550

Canberra \$540